

football's traditional powers.

"FIFA has brought the knowledge, the expertise, their analyst, their coaches, and we built this whole agentic AI layer on top of it. Today, 48 teams have the same data. All coaches can see the same thing that is happening," says Sheikh.

If FIFA AI Pro represents AI's influence on the sport itself, the technology's most ambitious contribution sits miles away from the nearest touchline.

Located in Miami, the company's Intelligent Command Centre functions as what Sheikh describes as the World Cup's "central nervous system". It connects venue operations, transportation networks, security systems, weather services and hundreds of other data streams across 16 venues, three countries and more than 200 training locations.

Before this tournament, many of those operations relied on a patchwork of spreadsheets, messaging platforms and disconnected software systems.

"What it does is that it has an AI agentic layer built on Lenovo's hybrid AI platform," Sheikh explains. "We connect all the systems and give predictive analysis."

Convincing stakeholders, however, was not always straightforward.

"I used to walk in with some ideas, and I used to get rejected," Sheikh, a former professional cricketer, recalls. "Today, those exact ideas are live."

Its importance became evident during France's group-stage match against Iraq in Philadelphia. Severe thunderstorms and

At the helm: Asia Sheikh, Global CTO, Sports & Entertainment Innovation, Lenovo, helped spearhead the AI technologies transforming the 2026 FIFA World Cup, from FIFA AI Pro and digital player avatars to the tournament's intelligent command centre.
SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

